



A **SUPER SCOOPER** drops water on the Palisades fire on Jan. 7. “This is the first time in Cal Fire history that we’ve had 24-hour operations,” an official said. BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

Blazes hit an already struggling film world

L.A.-area disasters have worsened the industry crisis. Lost jobs may never return.

By DON LEE AND SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

As if Hollywood didn't have enough trouble getting back on its feet, the Los Angeles wildfires suspended filming, destroyed homes of stars and crews alike and even threatened the landmark Hollywood sign that towers over the city.

The devastation hit as film and TV industry workers were already struggling to adjust to vast technological, financial and global changes that have severely reduced L.A. area production activity and eliminated thousands of jobs that may never come back.

New data examined by The Times show that the number of jobs in L.A.'s film and TV business has barely budged since the strike by actors and writers ended in fall 2023.

And with slower-than-hoped for recovery from the strikes, combined with continuing runaway production and industry contraction, on-location filming in the L.A. region fell 5.6% last year [See **Hollywood**, A8]

Pilots navigate distinct challenge in L.A. firefight



DAVE HABIB conducts a preflight check on a Los Angeles Fire Department aircraft at Van Nuys Airport on Tuesday. Winter is typically the offseason for firefighting aircraft, when they undergo maintenance. CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

Aircraft and operators are pushed to the extreme in a busy airspace

By GRACE TOOHEY AND JACK DOLAN

A massive California Air National Guard tanker dives into a Pacific Palisades canyon full of smoke, as the ground below rushes up and fills the windshield. Sirens blare in the cockpit, and a recorded woman's voice warns, “Altitude! Altitude!”

The guard video, shot over the pilot's left shoulder, shows him aggressively working the yoke to keep the enormous plane airborne and on target to release a drenching stream of fire retardant. Next to his elbow, as Hollywood-level drama fills the rest of the frame, sits a bright red, undisturbed box of Chick-Fil-A takeout.

That's life for the roughly 100 fire pilots fighting the hot, dirty and dangerous battle to save Los Angeles from this week's punishing flames. It's a gritty, around-the-clock job — you eat when you can.

As the rest of us crane our necks skyward, or click on YouTube videos to watch what one Cal Fire official called the most intense, complicated airborne firefight in U.S. history, interviews with the pilots paint a graphic picture of the struggle to maintain control of their ships in extraordinarily treacherous conditions.

All that while circling over burning hillsides, watching people on the ground arm themselves with over- [See **Pilots**, A5]

Criticism, loyalty surround fire chief

Some say Crowley is a ‘DEI hire’ and call out her tactics. To others, she’s a hero.

By SONJA SHARP

It was just after noon on Friday, four days into the deadly conflagration in the Palisades, when Los Angeles Fire Chief Kristin Crowley suddenly seemed to crack.

“Three years I’ve been in this seat, I’ve sounded the alarm — we need more,” Crowley told Fox LA's Gigi Graciette during an extended live spot. “We are screaming to be properly funded so our firefighters can do our jobs. My job as chief is to make sure my voice is heard.”

“Did the City of Los Angeles fail you?” Graciette pressed her until almost 13 minutes into the interview, when Crowley drew a deep breath, flashed a bemused [See **Crowley**, A10]

Justices uphold ban on TikTok

High court, Congress agree on divestiture over app's China ties.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court on Friday upheld a law that calls for the shutdown of the U.S. operations of social media app TikTok due to privacy and security concerns related to its Chinese owner.

The justices in a unanimous opinion said the 2024 law does not violate the 1st Amendment or its protection for freedom of speech. The ruling means 170 million Americans may lose access to the popular social media platform as soon as Sunday.

“There is no doubt that, for more than 170 million Americans, TikTok offers a distinctive and expansive [See **TikTok**, A5]

Technically lawbreakers, neighbors call them heroes

Father and son in Palisades fire zone saved homes while refusing to evacuate.

By JAMES RAINEY

The fire refugees arrive with regularity at the checkpoint on Pacific Coast Highway. They come alone or in pairs, lining up behind the clutch of police cruisers and a National Guard Humvee, pleading to get back to homes inside the Palisades wildfire perimeter.

They want medicines and other necessities, sure. But they also want a sense of knowing: What has the great Palisades wildfire done to their homes and to their lives?

When Steve LaBella arrives, it's with an urgent request from his father, Len, who evacuated in such a rush on Jan. 7 that he left behind a treasured keepsake — a Purple Heart that his father, Leonard LaBella Sr., earned in Germany near the end of World War II.

Like virtually everyone else, Steve LaBella is turned away by a police officer. But then he spots a sunburned civilian on the inside of the checkpoint. He calls out to the stranger, who he later learns is Stephen Foster, who quickly agrees to take LaBella's house keys and look for the missing medal.

Twenty minutes later, Foster returns to PCH with not only the Purple Heart, but several family photos, wrapped carefully in a table- [See **Scofflaws**, A6]



STEPHEN Foster, left and his son, Colton, have stayed at their home near the Getty Villa, delivering essentials to others who refused to leave the neighborhood. GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

MORE FIRE COVERAGE

How Australia adapted

A fire chief details the planning that followed a devastating 2003 blaze in Canberra. **WORLD**, A3

Filming locations gone

Popular homes burned. Now industry pros are helping document claims. **BUSINESS**, A7

Legislation for relief

Assembly members plan to introduce bills for recovery and rebuilding. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

ALSO INSIDE

Dodgers sign Sasaki

The highly coveted Japanese pitcher will join Ohtani and Yamamoto in L.A. **SPORTS**, B12

Weather

Some sun.

L.A. Basin: 63/43. **B8**



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